

A GENTLE HOME PRESCHOOL FOR ALEX

Alex & the Dinosaurs

Unit 1 • Plant-eaters with armor
3 weeks ready for play



 Alex can choose a dinosaur picture to explore, or a book to share.

Set it out. Play nearby.

Offer the day's two invitations and let Alex choose either, or neither. Hands first on the floor for **2–10 minutes**. Stop when they push back. One page and one parent card is plenty; no pencils, sitting lessons or finishing requirement.

A day can be this simple

A book · play together · outside · one small invitation · another book

Talk and listen

Name the dinosaur and notice what Alex notices. Let them point, gesture, or talk. Adults read all book captions in Unit 1.

Sounds first

Start from zero. Unit 1 introduces S /s/, T /t/, A /a/ within the initial s a t p i n set. Use sounds, not letter names; clip /t/ without an added "uh." Oral blending comes before letter-tile words. Tricky words wait until R4, two at a time.

Quantity means something

Start with 3–4 objects. Let Alex select the equal set or stop at the requested amount. Five is a stretch only when four is secure. Numerals ride along without testing.

Hands and thinking. Matching means pairing, placing or pointing; no draw-the-line pages before M1. Invite free circular hand movement and an optional fat-crayon circle. No hand guidance. Finger movement is practice, not evidence that M0 is met. Patterns leave the next item for Alex to choose.

Prepare once. Print US Letter at 100%, browser headers/footers off. Adult cuts the pieces described on each card. Playdough, magnet tiles, Lego, crayons, clips and rings are fine with a parent present. A sheet protector or washable mat makes dough cleanup easy. ALEX is on each page for optional finger exploration.

Notice without testing. If you want to remember something after play, use the short question on the card. Skip it whenever you like. Let them say no and come back another day. Run the play checks in the level check, then a Week 1 observation, before planning the next unit.

Alex's choice today: a picture game, or round play beside a dinosaur. A harder rung is on every day's card if they want more.

Small steps, one rung at a time

They aren't competing, so run both every week (that's how the weeks are built). The order that **does** matter is **within** each skill — climb one rung at a time. Unit 1 assumes a starting point of counting **1–4 objects with meaning**, no letters recognized yet, and no circle drawn yet. Run the level check first; start where Alex is, and let their response set the next rung.

The Number Ladder

6 Add within 5 with objects — optional stretch

5 Compare groups: more, fewer, same

LATER — RIDES ALONG CASUALLY

4 Connect written numerals to quantity

NEXT

3 Stop at 5 from a larger pile

START HERE

2 Count 1–4 objects with meaning

1 One touch per number word; separate rote counting

The Letter Ladder

6 Read decodable sentences and tell what happened

5 Build and read CVC words; tricky words from R4

4 Blend spoken sounds before word tiles

3 Connect the first six sounds to s a t p i n

2 Hear first sounds in familiar spoken words

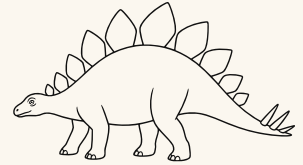
1 Enjoy books and notice print — no letters known yet

Alex can choose dot cards or a pile of blocks. Their decision: which has the same amount? If four is comfortable and they want more, offer five. Numerals ride along without testing.

Stegosaurus

Color, squash, build, and find a match.

STEG-oh-SORE-us · Ate plants · Late Jurassic
Stegosaurus had back plates and tail spikes.



THIS WEEK'S LETTER

S

/s/ — a quiet, steady hiss.

THIS WEEK'S NUMBER IDEA

Match 3, then 4; stop at the amount requested.

COLOR OF THE WEEK

● green

Big idea: One dinosaur, many ways to notice.

LETTER TIP Say /s/, not the letter name. Let them listen or echo.

NUMBER TIP Match three, then four. Keep numeral strips aside while matching; five is for another willing turn.

👐 Five gentle activities — one a day

MONDAY

Hello, Stegosaurus!

Want to color Stegosaurus, or roll a dough loop for it?

Alex decides: Which spoken word starts with /s/: sun or cup?

If welcome: If that sound game is easy, try a fresh spoken pair: ball or sock.

TUESDAY

Match the eggs

Want to make dough eggs, or build their pen with magnet tiles?

Alex decides: Which card has the same number of eggs as the target?

If welcome: Empty the pen, gather eight dough eggs outside it, and invite five if four was easy.

WEDNESDAY

Find Stegosaurus's shadow

Want to find Stegosaurus's shadow, or hide its picture for me?

Alex decides: Which of the three dinosaur shadows belongs to Stegosaurus?

If welcome: Hide the picture and invite its name and food while they look at the shadow.

THURSDAY

What comes next?

Want to build a tile trail, or choose the next picture?

Alex decides: Which picture continues the leaf-egg pattern?

If welcome: After their first tile choice, offer one more place, with both colors available again.

FRIDAY

A book for Stegosaurus

Want to turn the pages while I read, or make a dough resting place first?

Alex decides: Which picture word starts with /s/: ball or sock?

If welcome: Cover the pictures and invite the sound for S, if they want another turn.

BOOK BASKET · PICK ONE

- **Dinosaur Roar!** · Paul & Henrietta Stickland
Choose a favorite picture.
- **How Do Dinosaurs Say Good Night?** · Jane Yolen; art: Mark Teague
Hear /s/ at the start of "say."
- **Ten Little Dinosaurs** · Mike Brownlow; art: Simon Rickerty
Count a few; no need to reach ten.

SONGS · PICK ONE

- We Are the Dinosaurs — Laurie Berkner. March or sway.
- Five Enormous Dinosaurs — traditional. Stomp and count a few.
- Stomp Like a Dinosaur — Super Simple. Hear /s/ in "stomp."

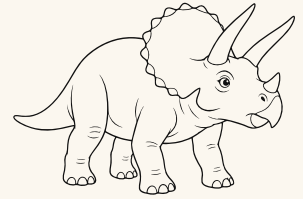
YOU'LL NEED

- Pages, scissors, crayons, scrap paper
- Playdough, washable mat
- 8 magnet tiles (4 each of 2 colors), cloth

Triceratops

Three horns and a week of playful choices.

try-SAIR-uh-tops · Ate plants · Late Cretaceous
Triceratops had three horns and a frill.



THIS WEEK'S LETTER

T

/t/ — clipped, with no added "uh."

THIS WEEK'S NUMBER IDEA

Choose the food; give four from a pile of eight.

COLOR OF THE WEEK

● **blue**

Big idea: One dinosaur, many ways to notice.

LETTER TIP Say /t/, not the letter name. Clip /t/ without adding "uh."

NUMBER TIP Serve four from a pile of eight. Keep extras within reach; let them decide when to stop. Five only if they want more.

🐾 Five gentle activities — one a day

MONDAY

Hello, Triceratops!

Want to color Triceratops, or roll a dough loop for it?

Alex decides: Which spoken word starts with /t/: sock or towel?

If welcome: If that sound game is easy, try a fresh spoken pair: sun or tap.

TUESDAY

Dinner for Triceratops

Want to squash a leafy dinner, or build Triceratops a pen?

Alex decides: Which food belongs to Triceratops, and when are four leaves enough?

If welcome: Clear the plate, return all eight leaves, and invite five if four was easy.

WEDNESDAY

Who ate something different?

Want to tell a dinosaur dinner story, or hide a picture after the story?

Alex decides: Which dinosaur ate meat instead of plants?

If welcome: Invite the hidden dinosaur's name and food before uncovering it.

THURSDAY

What comes next?

Want to build a tile trail, or choose the next picture?

Alex decides: Which picture continues the Stegosaurus–Triceratops pattern?

If welcome: After their first tile choice, offer one more place, with both colors available again.

FRIDAY

A book for Triceratops

Want to turn the pages while I read, or make a dough resting place first?

Alex decides: Which picture word starts with /t/: towel or sock?

If welcome: Cover the pictures and invite the sound for T, if they want another turn.

BOOK BASKET · PICK ONE

- **Dinosaur Roar!** · Paul & Henrietta Stickland
Choose a favorite picture.
- **Ten Little Dinosaurs** · Mike Brownlow; art: Simon Rickerty
Hear /t/ at the start of "ten."
- **How Do Dinosaurs Say Good Night?** · Jane Yolen; art: Mark Teague
A familiar bedtime choice.

SONGS · PICK ONE

- We Are the Dinosaurs — Laurie Berkner. March or sway.
- Five Enormous Dinosaurs — traditional. Stomp and count a few.
- Twinkle Twinkle Little Star — traditional. Hear /t/ in "twinkle."

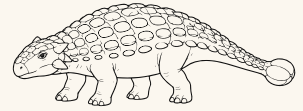
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Ankylosaurus

Armor, eggs, and a pattern to continue.

ANG-kih-loh-SORE-us · Ate plants · Late Cretaceous
Ankylosaurus had bony armor and a tail club.



THIS WEEK'S LETTER

A

/a/ — as in apple and ankle.

THIS WEEK'S NUMBER IDEA

Match 3–4; independently give four. Five if ready.

COLOR OF THE WEEK

● orange

Big idea: One dinosaur, many ways to notice.

LETTER TIP Say /a/, not the letter name. Let them listen or echo.

NUMBER TIP Match three, then four. Keep numeral strips aside while matching; five is for another willing turn.

🐾 Five gentle activities — one a day

MONDAY

Hello, Ankylosaurus!

Want to color Ankylosaurus, or roll a dough loop for it?

Alex decides: Which spoken word starts with /a/: apple or sun?

If welcome: If that sound game is easy, try a fresh spoken pair: leaf or ankle.

TUESDAY

Match the eggs

Want to make dough eggs, or build their pen with magnet tiles?

Alex decides: Which card has the same number of eggs as the target?

If welcome: Empty the pen, gather eight dough eggs outside it, and invite five if four was easy.

WEDNESDAY

Dinner for Ankylosaurus

Want to squash pretend leaves, or serve a dinosaur dinner?

Alex decides: Which food belongs to Ankylosaurus, and when are four leaves enough?

If welcome: Return all eight leaves to the pile and invite five if four was easy.

THURSDAY

What comes next?

Want to build a tile trail, or choose the next picture?

Alex decides: Which picture continues the Ankylosaurus–Stegosaurus pattern?

If welcome: After their first tile choice, offer one more place, with both colors available again.

FRIDAY

A book for Ankylosaurus

Want to turn the pages while I read, or make a dough resting place first?

Alex decides: Which picture word starts with /a/: sun or apple?

If welcome: Cover the pictures and invite the sound for A, if they want another turn.

BOOK BASKET · PICK ONE

- **Dinosaur Roar!** · Paul & Henrietta Stickland
Choose a favorite picture.
- **Apples and Pumpkins** · Anne Rockwell;
art: Lizzy Rockwell
Hear /a/ at the start of “apple.”
- **How Do Dinosaurs Say Good Night?** · Jane Yolen; art: Mark Teague
A familiar bedtime choice.

SONGS · PICK ONE

- We Are the Dinosaurs — Laurie Berkner. March or sway.
- Five Enormous Dinosaurs — traditional. Stomp and count a few.
- Apples & Bananas — Super Simple. First verse only: /a/ in “apple.”

YOU'LL NEED

- Pages, scissors, crayons, scrap paper
- Playdough, washable mat
- 8 magnet tiles (4 each of 2 colors), cloth